Westbrook School Committee

~ Finance Committee Meeting ~

Date: Wednesday, April 1, 2026
Time: 7:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1179362898
Packet: https://drive.google.com/file/d/1yHnAh8Kpb2Qo2JHpkNmrwVcpHl6wyKeh/view (Google Drive, via westbrookschools.org)

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *This was the fifth and intended-final Finance Committee budget session (ran roughly 4.5 hours); no votes were taken — the budget moves to the full School Committee as a recommendation. For complete context, nuance, and anything not covered, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Budget Schedule Change

Public Hearing & First Reading Pushed to April 8 [2:11]

Discussion Summary

Chair Mancuso announced the budget's public hearing and first reading, originally expected tonight, move to April 8 at 7:00 PM; second reading to April 13; and the City Council budget presentation (rescheduled by the City to accommodate the extra week) to April 15 at 6:00 PM, with the Council's own first vote April 27. The change gives the public fair notice once tonight's further budget changes are finalized.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — informational.

Action Items

None.

Working the Reduction List

Technology, Professional Development & Supplies [17:45]

Discussion Summary

Technology ($111,000 proposed cut): eliminates the new cybersecurity-focused Network Solutions Specialist position and defers the planned 11th-grade laptop-to-iPad transition, keeping older students on existing (six-plus-year-old) laptops. Dr. O'Donnell cautioned against reducing elementary device counts instead, citing curriculum and logistics disruption.

Professional development ($86,250 proposed cut) and supplies ($12,132 proposed cut) drew strong pushback, with members citing real harm from last year's full PD elimination. **Both were ultimately rejected and restored to the budget in full** (see Final Decisions below).

Key Decisions

✓ **No vote — budget review.**

Action Items

None.

Athletics, Facilities & Staff Reductions (Tiers 1 & 2) [01:39:49]

Discussion Summary

Athletics ($16,940) and Facilities ($42,350) reductions were largely confirmed as unspent amounts or deferrable items, not real cuts to opportunities; a new athletics-sponsorship revenue idea was floated for future committee follow-up.

Staff Tier 1 ($574,453.50 as proposed) eliminates several stipends, the Equity Resource Coordinator, three instructional coaches, and a vacant maintenance position, and reduces two staff schedules. City Administrator Angela Holmes gave a detailed School Resource Officer (SRO) cost breakdown here: the district pays 50% of SRO salary/benefits ($136,295.29) even though police data shows SROs spend 75–85% of their time on SRO-specific duties, not general patrol.

Staff Tier 2 eliminates a long-requested high school English teacher, a general education Ed Tech, the Multilingual Instructional Coach, and the two remaining elementary literacy/math coaches — described by staff as “getting close to the bone.”

Key Decisions

✓ **No vote — budget review.**

Action Items

None.

Point / Counterpoint: Is the City Underfunding Its Schools?

A Pointed Exchange on City Cost-Sharing [04:00:38]

Discussion Summary

As the reduction list review wound down, members voiced sharp frustration that peer communities devote a materially higher share of their municipal budgets to schools than Westbrook does, while the district pays the City for SROs and athletic-field maintenance without reciprocal City investment. Chair Mancuso offered a process framing: send the budget forward without further cuts and let the City Council and voters decide, rather than continue cutting tonight. No city commitment was reached on the record.

Key Decisions

✓ **No vote — discussion.**

Action Items

None.

Point / Counterpoint

> *“I'm really struggling with the fact that we're sitting here talking about taking out staff that helps our teachers teach better...the districts around us, the percentage of the municipal budget that goes to the schools is at least 10% higher than what we're doing here...it's not okay anymore.”*

— Katy Rice, Board Member [04:00:38]

> *“We can't keep saying that kids come first while funding them last...maybe [the City] can start with paying for SROs. And maybe they can start with not charging us $121,000 to mow and stripe our fields.”*

— Erin Cavallaro, Board Member [04:04:31]

> *“If the business I work for did that, you guys would not have groceries on your shelves.”*

— Noreen Poitras, Finance Committee Chair (on asking the City for a tax-revenue estimate) [04:08:34]

Final Decisions

What Stays, What's Cut, and What's Still Open [04:17:42]

Discussion Summary

Chair Poitras summarized the committee's consensus: Tier 1's leadership stipends and the English teacher position are kept (the English teacher decision held open pending further class-size data); all of Tier 2 is rejected (the elementary coaches, Multilingual Instructional Coach, and general education Ed Tech all stay); professional development and supplies stay fully funded. The technology, athletics, and facilities reductions proceed, along with the remaining Tier 1 staff items. The budget's contingency line increases to 0.5%, funded by removing a separate $25,000 emergency-repairs line. A pending health-insurance rate update (maximum 11%, possibly lower) could allow further last-minute adjustment before April 15. No final total dollar figure or percentage increase was stated on the record; a “version three” budget was still being assembled as the meeting closed.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — the budget moves to the School Committee's April 8 public hearing and first reading as a recommendation, not an approved document.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names against the official School Committee roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the Chair) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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